May 2025 has lent them huge credibility with prospective buyers.

For Nagpur-based Solar Industries, which has expanded from explosives and ammunition to a broader export portfolio that includes loitering munitions, counter-drone systems and rockets for the Pinaka system, the next phase is about converting international interest into sustained relationships. "The strong growth in defence exports demonstrates confidence in Indian products," says Dr Manjit Singh, director, Solar Industries. "The next step is to consistently deliver performance and quality at scale and establish India as a trusted long-term defence partner."

While industry insiders endorse India's ability to achieve its export targets, current numbers, they say, are influenced by a few large contracts. The challenge is to turn those successes into a steady stream of repeat orders and long-term programmes. For that to happen, certification and qualification processes must become faster and private firms must build capacity to manufacture at scale.

THE PRIVATE ENTERPRISE

One of the significant turnarounds in India's defence export story has been the growing role of private industry. Under the government's Make in India push, initiatives like Defence Procurement Procedure (DPP) 2016, Defence Acquisition Procedure (DAP) 2020 and 2026 and Innovations for Defence Excellence (iDEX) have simplified procedures, prioritised indigenous content and increased research funding and other support to the private sector. "India's defence exports are no longer being driven by public sector enterprises," says Ankit Mehta, CEO of the Navi Mumbai-based ideaForge Technology, makers and exporters of defence grade unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) or drones. "Private companies account for nearly half of India's defence exports, particularly in high-technology segments such as drones, electronics and EW systems."

Mehta's hopes, too, are buoyed by the growing confidence in Indian defence technologies. "India's competitive advantage will come from delivering mission-ready systems rather than being the lowest-cost manufacturer," he says. "What will decide export volumes is less demand than process: how long certification takes, whether domestic supply chains hold when they are tested, and whether companies keep funding in R&D. Winning a first export order is not the difficult part. Winning the second one is."

"The world is beginning to look at India not just as a defence supplier but as a defence technology partner. That could be far more significant for India's exports than numbers," says Ashok Atluri, chairman and MD of Hyderabad-based defence firm Zen Technologies. The company is seeing strong interest in its counter-drone systems as militaries grapple with the rapid evolution of UAV warfare.

Zen is also seeing growing international demand for its live, virtual, constructive (LVC) and mixed reality

ARMED BY INDIA

Some of the major export destinations for Indian defence products

THE PHILIPPINES
Purchases: BrahMos supersonic cruise missile system. Contract value: $375 million (Rs 3,579 cr)*

VIETNAM
Purchases: BrahMos (Estimated value of order: $629 million or Rs 6,000 cr), patrol boats, electronics, naval equipment

ARMENIA
Purchases: Akash air defence system, Pinaka multi-barrel rocket launcher, 155 mm artillery guns

INDONESIA
Orders: BrahMos, Astra air-to-air missile

UNITED STATES
Purchases: Aircraft components, aerospace structures, electronics, precision parts

FRANCE
Purchases: Aerospace components, electronic systems and sub-systems

ISRAEL
Purchases: Electronics, mechanical assemblies

NEPAL
Purchases: Military vehicles, ammunition, Dhruv helicopters, protective equipment

BANGLADESH
Purchases: Patrol boats, military vehicles

MAURITIUS
Purchases: Fast interceptor boats, Dornier aircraft, Dhruv helicopters

MALDIVES
Purchases: Coastal



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



MAKER'S PRIDE Akash air defence missiles (left) and Pinaka rockets in action

***Note:** Other than the BrahMos deal with the Philippines, the MoD has not divulged the export values of other defence products*